

PDFTools

Command-line tools for extracting text and rendering images from PDFs, built on Apple's PDFKit framework.

Tools

pdftotext

Extract plain text from a PDF file.

USAGE: `pdftotext <input> [<output>] [-f <f>] [-l <l>] [--npgbrk]`

ARGUMENTS:

`<input>` Input PDF file path
`<output>` Output text file path (omit to derive from input; '-' for stdout)

OPTIONS:

`-f <f>` First page to extract (1-based, default: 1)
`-l <l>` Last page to extract (default: last page)
`--npgbrk` Do not insert form feed between pages

If `<output>` is omitted, `document.pdf` is written to `document.txt`. Pass `-` to write to stdout.

Examples:

```
# Convert document.pdf -> document.txt
pdftotext document.pdf
```

```
# Write to stdout
pdftotext document.pdf -
```

```
# Save to a specific file
pdftotext document.pdf output.txt
```

```
# Extract only pages 3-5
pdftotext document.pdf -f 3 -l 5
```

```
# No page-break characters between pages
pdftotext document.pdf --npgbrk
```

pdftoppm

Convert PDF pages to raster images (PNG, JPEG, or TIFF).

USAGE: `pdftoppm <input> <output-prefix> [-r <r>] [-f <f>] [-l <l>]`

```
[-png] [-jpeg] [-tiff]
[-scale-to <n>] [-jpeg-quality <n>]
```

ARGUMENTS:

```
<input>           Input PDF file path ('-' to read from stdin)
<output-prefix>   Output filename prefix (e.g. "out" → "out-001.png")
```

OPTIONS:

```
-r <r>             Resolution in DPI (default: 150)
-f <f>            First page (1-based, default: 1)
-l <l>            Last page (default: last page)
-png              Output PNG format (default)
-jpeg             Output JPEG format
-tiff            Output TIFF format
-scale-to <n>     Scale so the longest side equals N pixels (overrides -r)
-jpeg-quality <n> JPEG quality 0-100 (default: 85)
```

Examples:

```
# Convert all pages to PNG at 150 DPI
pdftoppm document.pdf pages

# Convert page 1 only at 300 DPI
pdftoppm document.pdf pages -f 1 -l 1 -r 300

# Convert to JPEG, scale longest side to 1200px
pdftoppm document.pdf pages -jpeg -scale-to 1200

# Convert pages 2-4 to TIFF
pdftoppm document.pdf pages -f 2 -l 4 -tiff

# Read PDF from stdin
cat document.pdf | pdftoppm - pages
```

Output files are named <prefix>-001.png, <prefix>-002.png, etc., with zero-padding based on total page count.

Build

Requires macOS 14+ and the Xcode Command Line Tools or Xcode.

```
swift build -c release
```

Binaries will be at `.build/release/pdftotext` and `.build/release/pdftoppm`.

Install

```
cp .build/release/pdftotext .build/release/pdftoppm ~/bin/
```